

The Creative Zen Vision

The 30 GB Portable Media Center

A little after mid-2005, Creative rolled out its Zen Vision, a product aimed at the Portable Media Center segment.

The Creative Zen Vision sports a 3.7 inch 262K SharpPix™ colour screen with a maximum resolution of 640 x 480. The player makes an immediate impression with its large screen and black magnesium finish. Going beyond looks, it can transfer photos from Compact Flash cards on the fly, and it also supports playback of AVI, MPEG 1 and 2, WMV, and the DivX video formats. It also happens to be TiVoToGo-compatible, for viewing TiVo-recorded videos. Button placement is designed to suit single-handed operation. Most of the buttons for playback and navigation are located on the right; this makes it convenient for right-handed people, but is uncomfortable for left-hand use.

A high Signal-to-Noise Ratio (SNR) of 97 db means the Creative Zen Vision delivers dazzling sound quality. Music files can be transferred to the device from a PC through the USB 2.0 interface. The transfer and (if necessary) encoding of media files are executed by Zen Vision Media Explorer, a bundled software that enables synchronisation with the device. FM tuning with a 32-channel preset, as well as FM recording, are included.

Despite the high resolution and great colour screen, we found the viewing angle to be poor—the picture clarity is affected even if you move your wrist a little bit. This is an area where Creative Labs needs to work on. The large screen definitely adds to the pleasure of watching video on the go. Add to this the amazing sound quality and photo support, and what results is a wholesome Portable Media Center player.

What's more? The visionary Zen (pardon the pun) also includes an inbuilt microphone, and the interface displays volume levels for better-quality voice recording. The embedded Organiser provides Calendar, Tasks, and a Contact List, and syncs with Microsoft Outlook. You can choose to wake to your favourite music with the "Wake-to-any-music" alarm featured in the clock settings. Media files on the player can also be viewed on a TV through the A/V interface port.

Now let's talk price. Creative has priced its Zen Vision at Rs 29,900! Compare that to the Apple iPod 30 GB with video playback at 20K. But the iPod has a smaller screen and fewer colours at 64K, while the Zen Vision is more than double in both these features, at the same capacity. Plus, in order to interface the iPod to your TV, you'll need to purchase an AV connection kit, which costs about Rs 5,000. We think the 10K difference is more than justified!

our disappointment, only the Apple iPod and Creative Zen MicroPhoto have colour screens. While the Zen Micro and Sony NW-HD5 have respectable dot matrix LCD screens, the Zen Neon has a mediocre three-line LCD display. Only the Sony NW-A1000 and Creative Zen MicroPhoto have OLED screens. The latter features a 262K colour screen. It was really sad to see Sony's sexy NW-A1000 miss out on colours.

The Apple iPod maintains the standard 64K LCD colour screen. The screen has a wide viewing angle to complement its video playback capability.

Playback Formats

The Apple iPod rules in this department. It supports AAC, MP3, MP3 VBR, AIFF, WAV, and Audible, apart from its proprietary Apple Lossless. Sony supports MP3, and pushed its ATRAC3 format via its player. Any format other than MP3, such as WMA, would be converted to ATRAC3 by Sony's bundled software, called SonicStage. Creative maintains the standard MP3-WMA-WAV format support.

The iPod, in addition to audio, can play back videos in the M4V, MP4 and MOV formats. The Creative Zen MicroPhoto and Apple iPod support JPEG image viewing.

Flaunt Value

Looks matter, and the gadgets we're looking at here *should* have flaunt value! Apple did not have anything new to offer in terms of design. The iPod has just tanned from white to black. The design and dimensions, however, remain the same. But why change a good thing?

The Creative Zen MicroPhoto looks

better than its sibling, the Zen Micro, thanks to the subtle changes—or rather corrections—in the design of the latter's touchpad and edges, which reflect elegantly on the Zen MicroPhoto. The former, however, has not undergone any changes—perhaps Creative wanted to distinguish the two players in the same series without major restructuring.

The Creative Zen Neon looks mediocre—the screen has a multicoloured backlight, which just isn't cool anymore! Along similar lines, we didn't like the design of the Sony NW-HD5—poor screen, interface and portability.

The head-turner among the six products was Sony's NW-A1000. It was the sleekest and the most stylish of them all. The menu buttons are highlighted by a subtle backlight, while the unit's brilliance lies in its OLED display, encapsulated within its translucent front casing. You will have no idea about the boundary of the screen until you turn it on. The display is bright and visible even under direct sunlight. We just wish it had a colour display!

A Look At Features

The Apple iPod has a marginal advantage over the Creative Zen Photo as features go. It has support for a variety of audio formats, and adds miscellaneous stuff such as a volume limiter with a parental lock, a calendar and to-do, games, a world clock, and a stopwatch timer. Similarly, the Zen MicroPhoto has voice recording, a calendar, tasks, and themes, and it can also synchronise with Microsoft Outlook to import contacts.

The iPod has 22 inbuilt preset equaliser modes. However, you might



Sony A-1000